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The Washington Post

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Democracy Dies in Darkness

SUNDAY, MARCH 15, 2026 • \$6



KATARINA PREMFORIS/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

As Trump pushes uprising, Iranians ‘scared to move’

Sima, 33, is from Iran and lives in Dubai. Many Iranians say their families cheered Ayatollah Ali Khamenei's death but fear war may leave Iran in a worse place than before.

BY RACHEL CHASON
IN DUBAI

Iranians living here wake up every morning to calls from family members whose accounts of wartime Iran reveal in fragments the terror of life under attack by the United States and Israel.

Two weeks into the war that President Donald Trump initially said was intended to force regime change in Tehran, the Iranians living here say their families are mostly huddled at home, trying to avoid

both the U.S.-Israeli strikes and supporters of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC) patrolling the streets with guns.

Some who celebrated when they learned the supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, had been killed said they are still holding on to hope and spend short phone calls reassuring their family in Dubai, on the other side of the Persian Gulf, that positive change is coming.

But even those who initially supported the strikes by the U.S. and Israel say they are now struggling to

imagine the future. “If this war were to end now, we would be in an even worse place than we were before,” said Pivi, 36, an architect who, like others in this article, spoke on the condition of anonymity to protect her family in Iran.

Pivi said she hoped that eventually, people would take to the streets to demand a return to democracy, as her own family had during mass protests in Iran in December. “But right now,” she said, “most people are too scared to move.”

SEE IRAN ON A8

Tehran wages financial warfare

STRATEGY IMPERILS WEALTHY NEIGHBORS

Regime targets global economy in survival bid

BY DAVID J. LYNCH

As American and Israeli armed forces hunt Iranian missile launchers, radar sites and warships, Iran is taking aim at a different set of targets: the civilian institutions that define the modern age of globalization.

Tehran's strategy in what some are calling the third Persian Gulf War — following clashes in 1991 and 2003 — threatens to imperil its more prosperous neighbors' standing as a hub of global trade and finance. On Friday, the Dubai International Financial Center, home to banks such as Goldman Sachs and a Ritz-Carlton hotel, was hit by a drone attack, causing minor damage to one building.

At issue is more than the essential energy cargoes that are now blocked from transiting the Strait of Hormuz. Among Iran's first targets for retaliation after the initial U.S. and Israeli attack on Feb. 28 were Amazon data centers in the United Arab Emirates and Bahrain, symbols of those nations' technological ambitions.

On Wednesday, after a missile slammed into a downtown Tehran building belonging to state-

SEE ECONOMY ON A5

China could emerge from energy shock a winner

BY EVAN HALPER

As the threat of strikes by Iran forces oil tankers destined for Asia to idle in the Persian Gulf, some top Republicans have declared an economic victory against a rival super power. “This is China's nightmare,” Sen. Lindsey Graham (R-South Carolina) said on Fox News last week.

But the disruption caused by the war on Iran may reveal a different story about China: that years spent preparing for a global energy crisis have left the country and its economy better positioned than most to endure a long-term hike in the cost of oil and gas.

Through massive stockpiles of crude oil, an aggressive push into electric vehicles and huge investments into coal, renewable power

SEE CHINA ON A2

‘Slavery’ conditions described at Brazil EV factory



TERRENCE MCCOY/THE WASHINGTON POST

Workers building the BYD plant stage a protest in December outside the job site in Camaçari.

BY TERRENCE MCCOY
AND CHRISTIAN SHEPHERD
IN CAMAÇARI, BRAZIL

Colorado Road was never a place where much happened. Set off on the impoverished fringes of this obscure Brazilian city, it bore little of note beyond a small ballet school, a derelict sports club and a row of humble dwellings hidden behind decaying walls — until one day in May 2024, when Daniela de Oliveira opened her iron gate and heard a ruckus across the street.

Dozens of Chinese men were getting off a bus and heading into a pair of squat two-story buildings at the end of the road. Oliveira assumed the outsiders had some type of meeting and would soon be on their way. She'd been inside the structures, painted dark green, and knew they weren't nearly big enough to house them all.

But one day turned to the next, and soon Oliveira realized her new neighbors — 56 itinerant Chinese laborers, none of whom

SEE BRAZIL ON A9

Longest-lived animals offer clues about aging better

BY CAROLYN Y. JOHNSON
AND KATTY HUERTAS

A humble mollusk can live to 507. The oldest Greenland Sharks navigate deep, dark Arctic waters for longer than America has existed. And the wrinkly, cancer-resistant naked mole rat can live well into its 30s, a veritable rodent Methuselah.

Human centenarians excite a deep fascination. What are their secrets? Do they eat breakfast? Skip lunch? Exercise every day? What genes helped keep them strong and disease-free, years longer than most people? But across the animal kingdom, evolution has given rise to much vaster age gaps — and a growing scientific quest to understand what a menagerie of creatures

SEE ANIMALS ON A7

ARTS & STYLE.....E1
BUSINESS NEWS.....B7
COMICS.....INSERT

METRO.....B13
OBITUARIES.....B15
OPINION PAGES.....A15

@PKCAPITOL.....A2
POLITICS & NATION.....A4
SPORTS.....B1

TRAVEL.....F1
WEATHER.....B18
WORLD.....A6

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